

‘Everything is burned down’

OVER 6,000 STRUCTURES LOST IN DEVASTATING FIRESTORM



ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

A NEIGHBORHOOD destroyed by the Palisades fire. “It looks like Berlin [or] some part of World War II,” said actor and writer Steve Guttenberg, an area resident.

SIBLINGS’ FATES DIVERGE IN HAZE

BY JENNY JARVIE, SALVADOR HERNANDEZ, MATTHEW ORMSETH, GRACE TOOHEY AND NOAH HAGGERTY

“Victor, we have to get out!” Shari Shaw screamed as orange flames and thick smoke billowed toward her older brother’s modest 1960s bungalow in Altadena. “We have to get out of here!”

Victor Shaw, 66, a former courier driver who suffered from diabetes and chronic kidney disease, didn’t stir.

She shook him, but he didn’t respond. She gently kicked his feet.

“Victor, the fire is coming close,” she said. “It’s not safe to stay.”

“OK, let me just sit here for a few minutes,” he said.

“There’s no time to sit here!” Shari pleaded. “We have to get out!”

She fled as embers rained down on her SUV.

Shari survived; her brother died.

Officials have confirmed that at least five people were killed in firestorms that burned down large swaths of Pacific Palisades, Altadena and surrounding communities this week. But that number is likely to rise considerably as investigators search the rubble of thousands of damaged or destroyed homes.

“Unfortunately, I think the death toll will rise,” Los Angeles County Sheriff Robert Luna said.

In Altadena on Thursday, chain saws whirled as emergency crews hacked at toppled blackened trees and the charred remains of a house gutted by the Eaton fire crunched under the shoes of homicide detectives as they searched for human remains.

About a mile east, a county medical examiner van was parked on Monterosa Drive — a grim reminder that the official tally was unfinished.

And along the Malibu [See Altadena, A6]



CHRISTINA HOUSE Los Angeles Times

RICK NISHIYAMA of Huntington Beach walks along Lake Avenue in Altadena, where he grew up. The Eaton fire had burned over 13,600 acres as of Thursday.

Home insurance could get worse

BY LAURENCE DARMIENTO

When raging wildfires tore through Pacific Palisades and other local communities this week, they not only left a path of destruction reminiscent of a World War II bombing campaign,

but also threatened to deepen a crisis that has already left hundreds of thousands of Californians struggling to find and keep affordable homeowners insurance.

The multiple fires from Los Angeles to the San Gabriel Valley that have burned thousands of structures

since Tuesday — leading to losses that by one early estimate are well into the tens of billions of dollars — hit Southern California as insurers have been dropping customers statewide citing the increasing number and severity of wildfire-related [See Insurance, A6]

Palisades fire leaves a level of destruction L.A. has never seen

BY HANNAH FRY, DANIEL MILLER, NOAH HAGGERTY AND GRACE TOOHEY

The unprecedented scale of destruction in Pacific Palisades came into horrifying focus Thursday in the path of a fire that flattened a large swath of the community, rendering it unrecognizable.

As the smoke began to clear after two days of intense fire, Pacific Palisades appeared more like a moonscape of destruction than an upscale neighborhood known for its ocean views, beautiful vistas and celebrity denizens. Entire swaths of the residential district from its quaint village to the shores of the Pacific Ocean were completely gone, the architectural whimsy and lush landscaping reduced to burned-out ruins with white smoke still billowing from the wreckage.

It is a level of loss a Los Angeles community has not endured in recent memory — if ever — despite earthquakes, fires, floods and civil unrest. The devastation extended for miles. Some of the structures that survived — shopping centers, office buildings, a church, a school building, apartments, an occasional house — stood out in an otherwise featureless, battered and gray landscape. [See Palisades, A8]

Power outages, shutoffs upending lives

Thousands are still without power, and outages could last into and through the weekend. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

A foolish political blame game

Attacks fly bashing mayor’s response, but that’s just a distraction, writes Gustavo Arellano. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Tallying the cost of destruction

The economic loss could top \$50 billion. **BUSINESS, A10**

The race to save the Getty Villa

Timeline of museum’s team effort. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Climate ‘whiplash’ set the stage

BY IAN JAMES

The devastating wildfires that have ravaged Southern California erupted following a stark shift from wet weather to extremely dry weather — a phenomenon scientists describe as “hydroclimate whiplash.”

New research shows these abrupt wet-to-dry and

dry-to-wet swings, which can worsen wildfires, flooding and other hazards, are growing more frequent and intense because of human-caused climate change.

“We’re in a whiplash event now, wet to dry, in Southern California,” said Daniel Swain, a UCLA climate scientist who led the research. “The evidence shows that hydroclimate

whiplash has already increased due to global warming, and further warming will bring about even larger increases.”

The extreme weather shift over the last two years in Southern California is one of many such dramatic swings that scientists have documented worldwide in recent years. [See Whiplash, A8]

Infernos or no, their work continues

BY JACK DOLAN

As an enormous plume of dark gray smoke rose hundreds of feet from the nearby Palisades fire on Wednesday afternoon, obscuring the sun and turning everything in the north end of Santa Monica an apocalyptic shade of orange, a small army of workers went about their business as if it were

just another day on the job.

Amid the tension and anxiety in this normally cozy seaside enclave, landscapers kept trimming, builders kept building, and delivery trucks steered around electric cars packed with fleeing residents.

The weather was “fine for trimming trees,” said Adrian Rodriguez, as he tossed a coiled garden hose into the back of an ancient Nissan

pickup. “The sparks aren’t falling yet.”

It was 3 p.m., and Rodriguez, who lives in Los Angeles but is originally from Querétaro, Mexico, had already put in an eight-hour day as one of the worst natural disasters in California history raged around him.

Most of his labor was a little farther from the fire line, he pointed out. [See Work, A6]



SAUL LOEB Associated Press

A PRESIDENT’S FAREWELL

Jimmy Carter’s casket is carried to a hearse after his state funeral in Washington. **NATION, A4**

Trump plea on sentencing fails

The Supreme Court rejects the president-elect’s last-ditch effort in his hush money conviction. **NATION, A5**

Weather
Hazy sunshine.
L.A. Basin: 70/46. **B6**

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Bad Bunny’s ode to Puerto Rico

Artist honors his home island’s past on “Debi Tirar Más Fotos.” **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

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